COLLEGE SUCCESS

Cengage Learning

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College Success

Cengage Learning

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Planning for Sucess

Imagine a person who walks up to a counter at the airport to buy a plane ticket for his next vacation. “Just give me a ticket,” he says to the reservation agent. “Anywhere will do.”

The agent stares back at him in disbelief. “I’m sorry, sir,” she replies. “I’ll need some more details. Just minor things—such as the name of your destination city and your arrival and departure dates.”

“Oh, I’m not fussy,” says the would-be traveler. “I just want to get away. You choose for me.”

Compare this person to another traveler who walks up to the counter and says, “I’d like a ticket to Ixtapa, Mexico, departing on Saturday, March 23, and returning Sunday, April 7. Please give me a window seat, first class, with vegetarian meals.”

Now, ask yourself which traveler is more likely to end up with a vacation that he’ll enjoy.

The same principle applies in any area of life, including school. Suppose that you asked someone what she wanted from her education and you got this answer: “I plan to get a degree in journalism, with double minors in earth science and Portuguese, so that I can work as a reporter covering the environment in Brazil.” The details of a person’s vision offer clues to her skills and sense of purpose.

Discovering what you want and having a plan to get there helps you succeed in higher education. Many students quit school simply because they are unsure about what they want from it. With well-defined goals in mind, you can look for connections between what you want and what you study. The more connections, the more likely you’ll stay in school—and get what you want in every area of life.

By design, you are a learning machine. As an infant, you learned to walk. As a toddler, you learned to talk. By the time you reached age 5, you had mastered many skills needed to thrive in the world. And you learned all these things without formal instruction, without lectures, without books, without conscious effort, and without fear.

Shortly after we start school, however, something happens to us. Somehow, we start forgetting about the successful student inside us. Even under the best teachers, we experience the discomfort that sometimes accompanies learning. We start avoiding situations that might lead to embarrassment. We turn away from experiences that could lead to mistakes. We accumulate a growing list of ideas to defend, a catalog of familiar experiences that discourage us from learning anything new. Slowly, we restrict our possibilities and potentials.

However, don’t let this become your journey. You can take a new path in your life, starting today. You can rediscover the natural learner within you. Each module in this course is about a step you can take on your journey to becoming a successful student.

Thumbnail: www.pexels.com/photo/man-wearing-black-and-white-stripe-shirt-looking-at-white-printer-papers-on-the-wall-212286/

1.1: What Is a Successful Student?

Introduction

Becoming a successful student means mastering learning for you, based on your skills and personal characteristics.

Mastery means attaining a level of skill that goes beyond technique. For a master, work is effortless and struggle evaporates. The master carpenter, for example, is so familiar with her tools that they are part of her. To a master chef, utensils are old friends. Because these masters don't have to think about the details of the process, they bring more of themselves to their work.

Likewise, the successful student is one who masters her learning and makes learning look easy. She works hard without seeming to make any effort. She's relaxed *and* alert, disciplined *and* spontaneous, focused *and* fun-loving.

You might say that those statements don't make sense. Actually, mastery does *not* make sense. It cannot be captured in words. It defies analysis. It cannot be taught. It can only be learned and experienced.

Do you possess the skills and characteristics of a successful student?

Characteristics of a Successful Student

Successful students share certain qualities. These are attitudes and core values. Although they imply various strategies for learning, they ultimately go beyond what you do. These qualities are ways of *being* exceptional.

As you read the following list of qualities common to successful students, look to yourself. Make a list of each quality that you already demonstrate. Make another list of each quality that you want to possess. This is not a test. It is simply a chance to celebrate what qualities you possess so far—and to start thinking about what's possible for your future.

Inquisitive. A successful student is curious about everything. By posing questions, she can generate interest in the most mundane, humdrum situations. When she is bored during a biology lecture, she thinks to herself, "I always get bored when I listen to this instructor. Why is that? Then she asks herself, "What can I do to get value out of this lecture, even though it seems boring?" And she finds an answer.

Competent. Mastery of skills is important to a successful student. When he learns mathematical formulas, he studies them until they become second nature. He practices until he knows them cold and then puts in a few extra minutes of practice. He also is able to apply what he learns to new and different situations.

Joyful. More often than not, a successful student is seen with a smile on her face—sometimes a smile at nothing in particular other than amazement at the world and her experience of it.

Energetic. Notice the student with a spring in his step, the one who is enthusiastic and involved in class. When he reads, he often sits on the very edge of his chair, and he plays with the same intensity. He is determined and persistent. He is a successful student.

Self-aware. A successful student is willing to evaluate herself and her behavior. She regularly tells the truth about her strengths and those aspects that could be improved.

Responsible. There is a difference between responsibility and blame, and successful students know it well. A successful student is willing to take responsibility for everything in his life. He remembers that by choosing his thoughts and behaviors, he can create interesting classes, enjoyable relationships, fulfilling work experiences, and just about anything else he wants.

Courageous. A successful student admits her fear and fully experiences it. For example, she will approach a tough exam as an opportunity to explore feelings of anxiety and tension related to the pressure to perform. She does not deny fear but embraces it. If she doesn't understand something or makes a mistake, she admits it. When she faces a challenge and bumps into her limits, she asks for help. And she's just as willing to give help as to receive it.

Self-directed. Rewards or punishments provided by others do not motivate a successful student. His desire to learn comes from within, and his goals come from himself. He competes like a star athlete—not to defeat other people but to push himself to the next level of excellence.

Spontaneous. A successful student is truly in the here and now. She is able to respond to the moment in fresh, surprising, and unplanned ways.

Tech savvy. A successful student defines *technology* as any tool that is used to achieve a human purpose. From this point of view, computers become tools for deeper learning, higher productivity, and greater success in the workplace. He searches for information efficiently, thinks critically about data, and uses technology to create online communities. If he isn't familiar with a type of technology, he doesn't get overwhelmed. Instead, he embraces learning about the new technology and finding ways to use it to help him succeed at a given task.

Intuitive. A successful student has an inner sense that cannot be explained by logic alone. She trusts her gut instincts as well as her mind.

Creative. Where others see dull details and trivia, a successful student sees opportunities to create. He can gather pieces of knowledge from a wide range of subjects and can put them together in new ways. A successful student is creative in every aspect of his life.

Optimistic. A successful student sees setbacks as temporary and isolated, knowing that she can choose her response to any circumstance.

Hungry. Human beings begin life with a natural appetite for knowledge. In some people, it soon gets dulled. A successful student has tapped that hunger, and it gives him a desire to learn for the sake of learning.

Caring. A successful student cares about knowledge and has a passion for ideas. She also cares about other people and appreciates learning from them. She collaborates on projects and thrives on teams. She flourishes in a community that values win-win outcomes, cooperation, and love.

Reading: Actions and Behaviors of a Successful Student

In addition to improving personal characteristics, successful students must be willing to take actions that would contribute to her success. Which of the following are you willing to do?

Willing to change. The unknown does not frighten a successful student. In fact, she welcomes it—even the unknown in herself. We all have pictures of who we think we are, and these pictures can be useful. But they also can prevent learning and growth. A successful student is open to changes in her environment and in herself.

Willing to take risks. A successful student often takes on projects with no guarantee of success. He participates in class discussions at the risk of looking foolish. He tackles difficult subjects in term papers. He welcomes the risk of a challenging course.

Willing to participate. Don't look for a successful student on the sidelines. She is in the game. She is a team player who can be counted on. She is engaged at school, at work, and with friends and family. She is willing to make a commitment and to follow through on it.

Willing to accept paradox. The word *paradox* comes from two Greek words: *para* (meaning *beyond*) and *doxen* (meaning *opinion*). A paradox is something that is beyond opinion or, more accurately, that seems contradictory or absurd yet might actually have meaning. For example, a successful student can be committed to managing money and reaching his financial goals. At the same time, he can be totally detached from money, knowing that his real worth is independent of how much money he has. A successful student recognizes the limitations of the mind and is at home with paradox. He can accept that ambiguity.

Willing to be uncomfortable. A successful student does not place comfort first. When discomfort is necessary to reach a goal, she is willing to experience it. She can endure personal hardships and can look at unpleasant things with detachment.

Willing to laugh. A successful student might laugh at any moment, and his sense of humor includes the ability to laugh at himself. Going to school is a big investment with high stakes, but you don't have to enroll in the deferred-fun program. A successful student celebrates learning, and one of the best ways to do so is to laugh every now and then.

Willing to work. Once inspired, a successful student is willing to follow through with sweat. She knows that genius and creativity are the result of persistence and work. When in high gear, a successful student works with the intensity of a child at play.

Willing to make choices to be well. Health is important to a successful student, although not necessarily in the sense of being free of illness. Rather, he values his body and treats it with respect. He tends to his emotional and spiritual health as well as his physical health.

Reading: Personal Abilities of a Successful Student

In addition to possessing personal characteristics and qualities, a successful student also has specific abilities that contribute to his success. Which of the following abilities do you possess?

Able to focus attention. Watch a 2-year-old at play. Pay attention to his eyes. The wide-eyed look reveals an energy and a capacity for amazement that keep him absolutely focused on the here and now. The world, to a child, is always new. Because a successful student can focus attention, to him the world is always new, too.

Able to organize and sort. A successful student can take a large body of information and sift through it to discover relationships. She can organize data by size, color, function, time lines, and hundreds of other categories. She has the guts to set big goals and has the precision to plan carefully so that those goals can be achieved.

Able to suspend judgment. A successful student has opinions and positions, but he is able to let go of them when appropriate. He realizes he is more than his thoughts. He can quiet his internal dialogue and listen to an opposing viewpoint. He doesn't let judgment get in the way of learning. Rather than approach discussions with a "Prove it to me, and then I'll believe it" attitude, he asks himself, "What if this is true?" and then explores the possibilities.

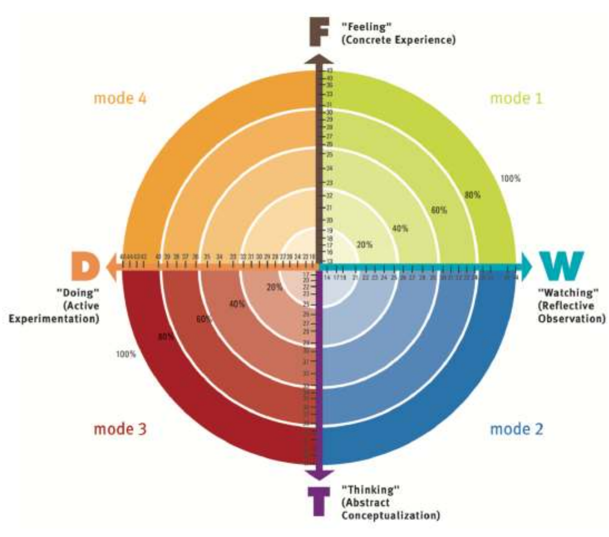
Able to be relaxed about grades. Grades make a successful student neither depressed nor euphoric. She recognizes that sometimes grades are important. At the same time, grades are not the only reason she studies. She does not measure her worth as a human being by the grades she receives.

Able to be a generalist. A successful student is interested in everything around him. In the classroom, he is fully present. Outside the classroom, he actively seeks out ways to deepen his learning—through study groups, campus events, student organizations, and team-based projects. Through such experiences, he develops a broad base of knowledge in many fields that he can apply to his specialties.

Ask yourself the following questions:

- Which of these characteristics of a successful student do you have?
- Which actions are you willing to take?
- Which abilities do you possess?
- Which characteristics, actions, and abilities do you need to work on?

Focus on strengthening those characteristics that you already possess, and continue to build on those you don't yet have. You are well on your way to success.



1.2: The Learning Process

Introduction

Right now, you are investing substantial amounts of time, money, and energy in your education. What you get in return for this investment depends on how well you understand the process of learning and use it to your advantage.

If you don't understand learning, you might feel bored or confused in class. After getting a low grade, you might have no idea how to respond. Over time, frustration can mount to the point that you question the value of being in school.

Some students answer that question by dropping out of school. These students lose a chance to create the life they want, and society loses the contributions of educated workers.

You can prevent that outcome. Gain strategies for going beyond boredom and confusion. Discover new options for achieving goals, solving problems, listening more fully, speaking more persuasively, and resolving conflicts between people.

Start by understanding the different ways that people create meaning from their experience and change their behavior. In other words, it is important to learn about *how* we learn.

The Learning Process: Perceiving and Processing

When we learn well, says psychologist David Kolb, two things happen. First, we perceive. That is, we notice events and "take in" new experiences.

Second, *we process*. We "deal with" experiences in a way that helps us make sense of them. According to Kolb (1984), each mode of learning represents a unique way of perceiving and processing our experiences. The following image illustrates the four modes of learning:

Mode 1: Concrete experience (feeling)

Mode 2: Reflective observation (watching)

Mode 3: Abstract conceptualization (thinking)

Mode 4: Active experimentation (doing)

Concrete experience. Some people prefer to perceive by *feeling* (also called *concrete experience*). They like to absorb information through their five senses. They learn by getting directly involved in new experiences. When solving problems, they rely on intuition as much as intellect. These people typically function well in unstructured classes that allow them to take initiative.

Reflective observation. Some people prefer to process by *watching* (also called *reflective observation*). They prefer to stand back, watch what is going on, and think about it. They consider several points of view as they attempt to make sense of things and generate many ideas about how something happens. They value patience, good judgment, and a thorough approach to learning.

Abstract conceptualization. Other people like to perceive by *thinking* (also called *abstract conceptualization*). They take in information best when they can think about it as a subject separate from themselves. They analyze, intellectualize, and create theories. Often, these people take a scientific approach to problem solving and excel in traditional classrooms.

Active experimentation. Other people like to process by *doing* (also called *active experimentation*). They prefer to jump in and start doing things immediately. These people do not mind taking risks as they attempt to make sense of things; this helps them learn. They are results oriented and look for practical ways to apply what they have learned.

Perceiving and Processing—An Example

Suppose that you're considering a new smartphone. It has more features than any phone you've used before. You have many options for learning how to use it. If you were to get the phone, which of the following would you tend to do to learn how to use it?

- Get your hands on the phone right away, press some buttons, and see whether you can browse online and access apps. This is an example of learning through concrete experience.
- Recall experiences you've had with phones in the past and what you've learned by watching other people use their phones. This is an example of learning through reflective observation.
- Read the instruction manual and view help screens on the phone before you try to make a call. This is an example of learning through abstract conceptualization.

- Ask a friend who owns the same type of phone to coach you as you experiment with making calls and sending messages. This is an example of learning through active experimentation.

In summary, your learning style is the unique way that you blend feeling, thinking, watching, and doing. You tend to use this approach in learning anything—from cell phones to English composition to calculus.

Reference

Kolb, David A. *Experiential Learning: Experience as the Source of Learning and Development.* Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1984.

The Learning Process: Multiple Intelligences

People often think that being smart means the same thing as having a high IQ, and that having a high IQ automatically leads to success. However, psychologists are finding that IQ scores do not always foretell which students will do well in academic settings—or after they graduate (Bernstein et al. 2006, 368–69).

Howard Gardner of Harvard University believes that no single measure of intelligence can tell us how smart we are. Instead, he defines intelligence in a flexible way as “the ability to solve problems, or to create products, that are valued within one or more cultural settings” (Gardner 1993). He also identifies several types of intelligences.

Multiple Intelligences

People using **verbal/linguistic intelligence** are adept at language skills and learn best by speaking, writing, reading, and listening. They are likely to enjoy activities such as telling stories and doing crossword puzzles.

People who use **mathematical/logical intelligence** are good with numbers, logic, problem solving, patterns, relationships, and categories. They are generally precise and methodical, and they are likely to enjoy science.

When people learn visually and by organizing things spatially, they display **visual/spatial intelligence**. They think in images and pictures and understand best by seeing the subject. They enjoy charts, graphs, maps, mazes, tables, illustrations, art, models, puzzles, and costumes.

People using **bodily/kinesthetic intelligence** prefer physical activity. They enjoy activities such as building things, woodworking, dancing, skiing, sewing, and crafts. They generally are coordinated and athletic, and they would rather participate in games than just watch.

Individuals using **musical/rhythmic intelligence** enjoy musical expression through songs, rhythms, and musical instruments. They are responsive to various kinds of sounds; remember melodies easily; and might enjoy drumming, humming, and whistling.

People using **intrapersonal intelligence** are exceptionally aware of their own feelings and values. They are generally reserved, self-motivated, and intuitive.

Outgoing people show evidence of **interpersonal intelligence**. They do well with cooperative learning and are sensitive to the feelings, intentions, and motivations of others. They often make good leaders.

People using **naturalist intelligence** love the outdoors and recognize details in plants, animals, rocks, clouds, and other natural formations. These people excel in observing fine distinctions among similar items.

Each of us has all of these intelligences to some degree. And each of us can learn to enhance them. Experiment with learning in ways that draw on a variety of intelligences—including those that might be less familiar. When we acknowledge all of our intelligences, we can constantly explore new ways of being strategic in our learning.

Reference

Bernstein, Douglas A., Louis A. Penner, Alison Clarke-Stewart, and Edward J. Roy. *Psychology.* Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 2006.

Gardner, Howard. *Frames of Mind: The Theory of Multiple Intelligences.* New York: Basic Books, 1993.

The Learning Process: Learning Through Your Senses—VAK

You can approach the topic of learning styles with a simple and powerful system—one that focuses on just three ways of perceiving through your senses:

1. Seeing, or visual learning

2. Hearing, or auditory learning
3. Movement, or kinesthetic learning

To recall this system of learning, remember the letters **VAK**, which stand for **visual**, **auditory**, and **kinesthetic**. The theory is that each of us prefers to learn through one of these senses. We can enrich our learning with activities that draw on the other channels.

To illustrate how each type of learners perceives and processes information, use the following questions to reflect on your VAK preferences. Each question has three possible answers. Write down the answer that best describes how you would respond in the stated situation. This is not a formal inventory—just a way to prompt some self-discovery.

When you have problems spelling a word, you prefer to

1. look it up in the dictionary.
2. say the word out loud several times before you write it down.
3. write out the word with several different spellings and then choose one.

You enjoy courses the most when you get to

1. view slides, overhead displays, videos, and readings with plenty of charts, tables, and illustrations.
2. ask questions, engage in small-group discussions, and listen to guest speakers.
3. take field trips, participate in lab sessions, or apply the course content while working as a volunteer or intern.

When giving someone directions on how to drive to a destination, you prefer to

1. pull out a piece of paper and sketch a map.
2. give verbal instructions.
3. say, "I'm driving to a place near there, so just follow me."

When planning an extended vacation to a new destination, you prefer to

1. read colorful, illustrated brochures or articles about that place.
2. talk directly to someone who's been there.
3. spend a day or two at that destination on a work-related trip before taking a vacation there.

You've made a commitment to learn to play the guitar. The first thing you do is

1. go to a library or music store and find an instruction book with plenty of diagrams and chord charts.
2. pull out your favorite CDs, listen closely to the guitar solos, and see whether you can play along with them.
3. buy or borrow a guitar, pluck the strings, and ask someone to show you how to play a few chords.

You've saved up enough money to lease a car. When choosing from among several new models, the most important factor in your decision is

1. the information you read from sources like *Consumer Reports*.
2. the information you get by talking to people who own the cars you're considering.
3. the overall impression you get by taking each car on a test drive.

You've just bought a new computer system. When setting up the system, the first thing you do is

1. skim through the printed instructions that come with the equipment.
2. call someone with a similar system and ask her for directions.
3. assemble the components as best as you can, see whether everything works, and consult the instructions only as a last resort.

You get a scholarship to study abroad next semester, which starts in just three months. You will travel to a country where French is the most widely spoken language. To learn as much French as you can before you depart, you

1. buy a video-based language course that's recorded on a DVD.
2. set up tutoring sessions with a friend who's fluent in French.
3. sign up for a short immersion course in an environment in which you speak only French, starting with the first class.

Now, take a few minutes to reflect on the meaning of your responses.

- All of the answers numbered "1" are examples of visual learning.
- Those numbered "2" refer to auditory learning.
- Those numbered "3" illustrate kinesthetic learning.

A consistent pattern in your answers indicates that you prefer learning through one sense channel more than others. Or you might find that your preferences are fairly balanced.

1.3: Planning for Success

Introduction

Now that you know more about how people learn, you want to think about how to apply it to your own learning. How do you learn best? How can you use that information to be a more successful student?

To learn more about your strengths and weaknesses as a learner, you can complete various inventories related to learning styles, attitudes, and motivations. For some of us, it's even harder to recognize our strengths than to recognize our weaknesses. Maybe we don't want to brag. Maybe we're attached to a poor self-image. The reasons don't matter. Part of becoming a successful student means telling the truth about our positive qualities, too.

Remember that weaknesses are often strengths taken to an extreme. The student who carefully revises her writing can make significant improvements in a term paper. If she revises too much and hands in the paper late, though, her grade might suffer. Any success strategy carried too far can backfire.

Figuring out how you learn and how to use that information is an important step in becoming a master student. You explored the various learning theories, and during this module, you will learn more about how to develop strategies to enhance your learning.

Planning for Success: Taking the First Steps

To succeed in school, tell the truth about what kind of student you are and what kind of student you want to become. Success starts with telling the truth about what is working—and what is not working—in our lives right now. When we acknowledge our strengths, we gain an accurate picture of what we can accomplish. When we admit that we have a problem, we are free to find a solution. Ignoring the truth, on the other hand, can lead to problems that stick around for decades.

Let's be truthful: It's not fun to admit our weaknesses. Many of us would approach a frank evaluation of ourselves about as enthusiastically as we would greet a phone call from the bank about an overdrawn account.
There is another way to think about self-evaluations. If we could see them as opportunities to solve problems and take charge of our lives, we might welcome them. Believe it or not, we can begin working with our list of weaknesses by celebrating them.

Whether written or verbal, the ways that we express our self-analysis are more powerful when they are specific. For example, if you want to improve your note-taking skills, you might write, "I am an awful note taker," but it would be more effective to write, "I can't read 80 percent of the notes I took in Introduction to Psychology last week, and I have no idea what was important in that class."

Be just as specific about what you plan to achieve. You might declare, "I want to take legible notes that help me predict what questions will be on the final exam."

As you use the results of your self-analysis, you might feel surprised at what you discover. Just tell the truth about it. The truth has power.

It is important for you to discover and acknowledge your own strengths as well as your areas for improvement. For many students, this is difficult to do. Some people suggest that looking at areas for improvement means focusing on personal weaknesses. They view it as a negative approach that runs counter to positive thinking. Positive thinking is a great technique. So is telling the truth, especially when we see the whole picture—the negative aspects as well as the positive ones.

To start your self-analysis, use the following suggestions as a guideline.

Be specific. It is not effective to write, "I can improve my communication skills." Of course you can. Instead, write down precisely what you can do to improve your communication skills. For example, "I can spend more time really listening while the other person is talking, instead of thinking about what I'm going to say next."

Be self-aware. Look beyond the classroom. What goes on outside school often has the greatest impact on your ability to be an effective student. Consider your strengths and weaknesses that you may think have nothing to do with school.

Be courageous. Self-analysis calls for an important master student quality—courage. It is a waste of time to do this if this is done half-heartedly. Be willing to take risks. You might open a door that reveals a part of yourself that you didn't want to admit was there.

Strengths

Examine your strengths by thinking about the following:

- One area where I show strong skills is ...
- Another area of strength is ...

Goals

Think about the areas you need to improve and make them your goals:

- The area in which I most want to improve is ...
- It is also important for me to get better at ...
- I want to concentrate on improving these areas because ...
- To meet my goals for improvement, I intend to ...

Planning for Success: Self-Analysis Using Discovery Statements

One way of thinking about success or failure is to focus on habits. Behaviors such as ignoring reading assignments or skipping class might be habits that lead to outcomes that *could not* be avoided—including dropping out of school. In the same way, behaviors such as completing assignments and attending class might lead to the outcome of getting an A.

When you confront a behavior that undermines your goals or creates a circumstance that you don't want, consider a new attitude: That behavior is just a habit. And it can be changed.

Thinking about ourselves as creatures of habit actually gives us power. In that way, we are not faced with the monumental task of changing our very nature. Rather, we can take on the doable job of changing our habits. One consistent change in behavior that seems insignificant at first can have effects that ripple throughout your life. Following are ways to test this idea for yourself.

One way to put your self-analysis into action is by journaling about your behaviors and habits and then creating discovery and intention statements.

Discovery Statements

Through **discovery statements**, you gain *awareness* of "where you are." These statements are a record of what you are learning about yourself as a student—both your strengths and your weaknesses. Discovery statements can also be declarations of your goals, descriptions of your attitudes, statements of your feelings, transcripts of your thoughts, and chronicles of your behaviors.

Sometimes, discovery statements chronicle an a-ha! moment—a flash of insight that results when you connect a new idea with your previous experiences, preferred styles of learning, or both. Perhaps a solution to a long-standing problem suddenly occurs to you. Or a life-changing insight wells up from the deepest recesses of your mind. Don't let such moments disappear. Capture them in discovery statements.

Record the specifics about your thoughts, feelings, and behavior. Notice your thoughts, observe your actions, and record them accurately. Get the facts. If you spent 90 minutes to checking your social media feed instead of reading your anatomy text, write about it. Include details.

Use discomfort as a signal. When you approach a daunting task, such as a difficult math problem, notice your physical sensations. Feeling uncomfortable, bored, or tired might be a signal that you're about to do valuable work. Stick with it. Write about it. Tell yourself you can handle the discomfort just a little bit longer. You will be rewarded with a new insight.

Suspend judgment. When you are discovering yourself, be gentle. Suspend self-judgment. If you continually judge your behaviors as "bad" or "stupid," your mind will quit making discoveries. For your own benefit, be kind to yourself.

Tell the truth. Suspending judgment helps you tell the truth about yourself. "The truth will set you free" is a saying that endures for a reason. The closer you get to the truth, the more powerful your discovery statements. If you notice that you are avoiding the truth, don't blame yourself. Just tell the truth about it.

Planning for Success: Taking Actions Using Intention Statements

Intention statements can be used to alter your course. These statements are about your *commitment* to take action based on increased awareness. An intention arises out of your choice to direct your energy toward a specific task and to aim at a particular goal. The processes of discovery and intention reinforce each other.

Even simple changes in behavior can produce results. If you feel like procrastinating, then tackle just one small, specific task related to your intention. Find something you can complete in minutes or less, and do it *now*. For example, access just one website related to the topic of your next assigned paper. Spend just 3 minutes previewing a reading assignment. Taking baby steps like these can move you into action with grace and ease.

Make intentions positive. The purpose of writing intention statements is to focus on what you want rather than what you don't want. Instead of writing, "I will not fall asleep while studying chemistry," write, "I intend to stay awake when studying chemistry." Also, avoid the word *try*. Trying is not doing. When we hedge our bets with try, we can always tell ourselves, "Well,

I *tried* to stay awake."

Make intentions observable. Rather than writing, "I intend to work harder on my history assignments," write, "I intend to review my class notes, and I intend to make summary sheets of my reading."

Make intentions small and achievable. Break large goals into small, specific tasks that can be accomplished quickly. Small and simple changes in behavior—when practiced consistently over time—can have large and lasting effects.

When setting your goals, anticipate self-sabotage. Be aware of what you might do, consciously or unconsciously, to undermine your best intentions. Also, be careful with intentions that depend on other people. If you intend for your study group to complete an assignment by Monday, then your success depends on the students in the group. Likewise, you can support your group's success by following through on your stated intentions.

Set time lines. For example, if you are assigned a paper to write, break the assignment into small tasks and set a precise due date for each one: "I intend to select a topic for my paper by 9:00 A.M. Wednesday."

Move from intention to action. Intention statements are of little use until you act on them. If you want new results in your life, then take action. Life responds to what you *do*.

Planning for Success: Identifying and Changing Habits

Discovery leads to awareness. Intention leads to commitment, which naturally leads to focused action.

The processes of discovery, intention, and action create a dynamic and efficient cycle. First, you write discovery statements about where you are now. Second, you write intention statements about where you want to be and the specific steps you will take to get there. Finally, follow up with action—the sooner, the better. Then, start the cycle again. Write discovery statements about whether or how you act on your intention statements—and what you learn in the process. Follow up with more intention statements about what you will do differently in the future. Then, move into action and describe what happens next.

This process never ends. Each time you repeat the cycle, you get new results. It's all about getting what you want and becoming more effective in everything you do. This is the path of mastery—a path that you can travel for the rest of your life.

Don't panic when you fail to complete an intended task. Straying off course is normal. Simply make the necessary corrections. Consider the first word in the title of the textbook—*becoming*. This word implies that mastery is not an end state or final goal. Rather, mastery is a process that never ends.

Miraculous progress might not come immediately. Do not be concerned. Stay with the cycle. Give it time. Use discovery statements to get a clear view of your world. Then, use intention statements to direct your actions. Whenever you notice progress, record it.

It can take the same amount of energy to get what you don't want in school as it takes to get what you do want. Sometimes getting what you *don't* want takes even more effort.

Planning for Success: Thinking About Motivation

Motivation is an important part of being a successful student. There are at least two ways to think about motivation. One is that the terms *self-discipline*, *willpower*, and *motivation* describe something missing in ourselves. We use these words to explain another person's success—or our own shortcomings: "If I were more motivated, I'd be more successful in school."

The other approach to thinking about motivation is to stop assuming that motivation is mysterious, determined at birth, or hard to come by. Motivation could be something that you already possess—the ability to do a task even when you don't feel like it. This is a habit that you can develop with practice.

Promise it. Motivation can come simply from being clear about your goals and acting on them. Say that you want to start a study group. You can commit yourself to inviting people and setting a time and place to meet. Promise your classmates that you'll do this, and ask them to hold you accountable. Self-discipline, willpower, and motivation—none of these mysterious characteristics has to get in your way. Just make a promise and keep your word.

Befriend your discomfort. Once you're aware of your discomfort, stay with it a few minutes longer. Don't judge it as good or bad. Accepting discomfort robs it of power. It might still be there, but in time it can stop being a barrier for you. Discomfort can be a gift—an opportunity to do valuable work on yourself. On the other side of discomfort lies mastery.

Change your mind—and your body. You can also get past discomfort by planting new thoughts in your mind or changing your physical stance. For example, instead of slumping in a chair, sit up straight or stand up. Get physically active by taking a short walk. Notice what happens to your discomfort.

Work with your thoughts. Replace "I can't stand this" with "I'll feel great when this is done" or "Doing this will help me get something I want."

Sweeten the task. Sometimes it's just one aspect of a task that holds you back. You can stop procrastinating merely by changing that aspect. If distaste for your physical environment keeps you from studying, for example, then change that environment. Reading about social psychology might seem like a yawner when you're alone in a dark corner of the house. Moving to a cheery, well-lit library can sweeten the task.

Turn up the pressure. Sometimes motivation is a luxury. Pretend that the due date for your project has been moved up 1 month, 1 week, or 1 day. Raising the stress level slightly can spur you into action. In that way, the issue of motivation seems beside the point, and meeting the due date moves to the forefront.

Turn down the pressure. The mere thought of starting a huge task can induce anxiety. To get past this feeling, turn down the pressure by taking baby steps. Divide a large project into small tasks. In 30 minutes or less, you could preview a book, create a rough outline for a paper, or solve two or three math problems. Careful planning can help you discover many such steps to make a big job doable.

Ask for support. Other people can become your allies in overcoming procrastination. For example, form a support group and declare what you intend to accomplish before each meeting. Then, ask members to hold you accountable. If you want to begin exercising regularly, ask another person to walk with you three times per week. People in support groups, ranging from Alcoholics Anonymous to Weight Watchers, know the power of this strategy.

Compare the payoffs with the costs. Skipping a reading assignment can give you time to go to the movies. However, you might be unprepared for class and have twice as much to read the following week. Maybe there is another way to get the payoff (going to the movies) without paying the cost (skipping the reading assignment). With some thoughtful weekly planning, you might choose to give up a few hours of television and end up with enough time to read the assignment and go to the movies.

Heed the message. Sometimes lack of motivation carries a message that's worth heeding. An example is the student who majors in accounting but seizes every chance to be with children. His chronic reluctance to read accounting textbooks might not be a problem. Instead, it might reveal his desire to major in elementary education. His original career choice might have come from the belief that "real men don't teach kindergarten." In such cases, an apparent lack of motivation signals a deeper wisdom trying to get through.

Planning for Success: Maintaining a Positive Attitude

Visible measures of success—such as top grades and résumés filled with accomplishments— start with invisible assets called *attitudes*. Some attitudes will help you benefit from all the money and time you invest in higher education. Consider these examples: "Every course is worthwhile." "I learn something from any instructor." "The most important factors in the quality of my education are my own choices."

Other attitudes will render your investment worthless: "This required class is a total waste of time." "You can't learn anything from some instructors." "Success depends on luck more than anything else." "I've never been good at school."

You can change your attitudes through regular practice with affirmations and visualizations.

Affirm It

An affirmation is a statement describing what you want. The most effective affirmations are personal, positive, and written in the present tense.

To use affirmations, first determine what you want, and then describe yourself as if you already have it. To get what you want from your education, you could write, “I, Malika Jones, am a master student. I take full responsibility for my education. I learn with joy, and I use my experiences in each course to create the life that I want.”

If you decide that you want a wonderful job, you might write, “I, Peter Webster, have a wonderful job. I respect and love my colleagues, and they feel the same way about me. I look forward to going to work each day.”

Effective affirmations include detail. Use brand names, people’s names, and your own name. Involve all of your senses—sight, sound, smell, taste, and touch. Take a positive approach. Instead of saying, “I am not fat,” say, “I am slender.”

Once you have written an affirmation, repeat it. Practice saying it out loud several times a day.

Visualize It

Here’s one way to begin. Choose what you want to improve. Then, describe in writing what it would look like, sound like, and feel like to have that improvement in your life. If you are learning to play the piano, write down briefly what you would see, hear, and feel if you were playing skillfully. If you want to improve your relationships with your children, write down what you would see, hear, and feel if you were communicating with them successfully.

Once you have a sketch of what it would be like to be successful, practice seeing it in your mind’s eye. Whenever you toss the basketball, it swishes through the net. Every time you invite someone out on a date, the person says “yes.” Each test the teacher hands back to you is graded an A. Practice at least once a day. Then, wait for the results to unfold in your life.

Be clear about what you want, and then practice it.

Developing the Modes of Learning

As you have learned, one of the ways to think about your own learning process is to examine how you perceive and process information—your preferred learning mode. Each mode of learning represents a unique way of perceiving and processing:

- Concrete experience (feeling)
- Reflective observation (watching)
- Abstract conceptualization (thinking)
- Active experimentation (doing)

Although you may tend to favor one of the modes, developing all four modes offers many potential benefits. For example, you can excel in many types of courses and find more opportunities to learn outside the classroom. You can expand your options for declaring a major and choosing a career. You can also work more effectively with people who learn differently from you.

In addition, you’ll be able to learn from instructors no matter how they teach. Let go of statements such as “My teachers don’t get me” and “The instructor doesn’t teach to my learning style.” Replace those negative statements with more positive attitudes: “I am responsible for what I learn” and “I will master this subject by using several modes of learning.”

No matter which of these you’ve tended to prefer, you can develop the ability to use all four modes. You can explore new learning styles simply by adopting new habits related to each of these activities. Consider the following suggestions as places to start.

To Gain Concrete Experience (Feeling)

- See a live demonstration or performance related to your course content.
- Engage your emotions by reading a novel or seeing a video related to your course.
- Interview an expert in the subject you’re learning or a master practitioner of a skill you want to gain.
- Conduct role-plays, exercises, or games based on your courses.
- Conduct an informational interview with someone in your chosen career or “shadow” that person for a day on the job.
- Look for a part-time job, internship, or volunteer experience that complements what you do in class.
- Deepen your understanding of another culture and extend your foreign language skills by studying abroad.

To Gain More Reflective Observation (Watching)

- Keep a personal journal, and write about connections among your courses.
- Form a study group to discuss and debate topics related to your courses.
- Set up a website, blog, email listserv, or online chat room related to your major.
- Create analogies to make sense of concepts; for instance, see if you can find similarities between career planning and putting together a puzzle.
- Visit your course instructor during office hours to ask questions.
- During social gatherings with friends and relatives, briefly explain to them what your courses are about.

To Develop Abstract Conceptualization (Thinking)

- Take notes on your reading in outline form; consider using word-processing software with an outlining feature.
- Supplement assigned texts with other books, magazine and newspaper articles, and related websites.
- Attend lectures given by your current instructors and others who teach the same subjects.
- Take the ideas presented in text or lectures and translate them into visual form—tables, charts, diagrams, and maps.
- Create visuals and use computer software to recreate them with more complex graphics and animation.

To Gain More Active Experimentation (Doing)

- Conduct laboratory experiments or field observations.
- Go to settings where theories are being applied or tested.
- Make predictions based on theories you learn, and then see if events in your daily life confirm your predictions.
- Try out a new behavior described in a lecture or reading, and observe its consequences in your life.

The following chart identifies some of the natural talents people have, as well as challenges for people who have a strong preference for any one mode of learning. For example, if Mode 2 (Reflective Observation) is most like you, then look at the lower right-hand corner of the following chart to see whether it gives an accurate description of you.

Employing your Multiple Intelligences, Part 1

Gardner's (1993) theory of multiple intelligences complements the discussion of different learning styles. The main point is that there are many ways to gain knowledge and acquire new behaviors. You can use Gardner's concepts to explore a range of options for achieving success in school, work, and relationships.

The following list identifies each of the intelligences and describes the strategies you can use to develop more effective learning strategies. As you review each of the first three intelligences below, write down any of the characteristics that describe you. Also, identify learning strategies that you intend to use. Finally, note any of the possible careers that spark your interest.

Verbal/Linguistic

- Characteristics
  - You enjoy writing letters, stories, and papers.
  - You prefer to write directions rather than draw maps.
  - You take excellent notes from textbooks and lectures.
  - You enjoy reading, telling stories, and listening to them.
- Learning Strategies
  - Highlight, underline, and write notes in your textbooks.
  - Recite new ideas in your own words.
  - Rewrite and edit your class notes.
  - Talk to other people often about what you're studying.
- Careers
  - Librarian, lawyer, editor, journalist, English teacher, radio or television announcer

Mathematical/Logical

- Characteristics
  - You enjoy solving puzzles.
  - You prefer math or science class to English class.
  - You want to know how and why things work.
  - You make careful, step-by-step plans.
- Learning Strategies
  - Analyze tasks so that you can order them in a sequence of steps.
  - Group concepts into categories, and look for underlying patterns.
  - Convert text into tables, charts, and graphs.
  - Look for ways to quantify ideas—express them in numerical terms.
- Careers
  - Accountant, auditor, tax preparer, mathematician, computer programmer, actuary, economist, math or science teacher

Visual/Spatial

- Characteristics
  - You draw pictures to give an example or clarify an explanation.
  - You understand maps and illustrations more readily than text.
  - You assemble things from illustrated instructions.
  - You especially enjoy books that have a lot of illustrations.
- Learning Strategies
  - When taking notes, create concept maps, mind maps, and other visuals.
  - Code your notes by using different colors to highlight main topics, major points, and key details.
  - When your attention wanders, focus it by sketching or drawing.
  - Before you try a new task, visualize yourself doing it well.
- Careers
  - Architect, commercial artist, fine artist, graphic designer, photographer, interior decorator, engineer, cartographer

Reference

Gardner, Howard. *Frames of Mind: The Theory of Multiple Intelligences.* New York: Basic Books, 1993.

Employing your Multiple Intelligences, Part 2

Continue to review the next five multiple intelligences. Which intelligences seem to fit your learning preferences?

Bodily/Kinesthetic

- Characteristics
  - You use a lot of gestures when talking.
- Learning Strategies
  - Be active in ways that support concentration; for example, pace as you recite, read while standing up, and create flash cards.
  - Carry materials with you, and practice studying in several different locations.
  - Create hands-on activities related to key concepts; for example, create a game based on course content.
  - Notice the sensations involved with learning something well.
- Careers
  - Physical education teacher, athlete, athletic coach, physical therapist, chiropractor, massage therapist, yoga teacher, dancer, choreographer, actor

Musical/Rhythmic

- Characteristics
  - You often sing in the car or shower.
  - You easily tap your foot to the beat of a song.
  - You play a musical instrument.
  - You feel most engaged and productive when music is playing.
- Learning Strategies
  - During a study break, play music or dance to restore energy.
  - Put on background music that enhances your concentration while studying.
  - Relate key concepts to songs you know.
  - Write your own songs based on course content.
- Careers
  - Professional musician, music teacher, music therapist, choral director, musical instrument sales representative, musical instrument maker, piano tuner

Intrapersonal

- Characteristics
  - You enjoy writing in a journal and being alone with your thoughts.
  - You think a lot about what you want in the future.
  - You prefer to work on individual projects over group projects.
  - You take time to think things through before talking or taking action.
- Learning Strategies
  - Connect course content to your personal values and goals.
  - Study a topic alone before attending a study group.
  - Connect readings and lectures to a strong feeling or significant past experience.
  - Keep a journal that relates your course work to events in your daily life.
- Careers
  - Minister, priest, rabbi, professor of philosophy or religion, counseling psychologist, creator of a home-based or small business

Interpersonal

- Characteristics
  - You enjoy group work over working alone.
  - You have plenty of friends and regularly spend time with them.
  - You prefer talking and listening over reading or writing.
  - You thrive in positions of leadership.
- Learning Strategies
  - Form and conduct study groups early in the term.
  - Create flash cards, and use them to quiz study partners.
  - Volunteer to give a speech or lead group presentations on course topics.
  - Teach the topic you're studying to someone else.
- Careers
  - Manager, school administrator, salesperson, teacher, counseling psychologist, arbitrator, police officer, nurse, travel agent, public relations specialist, creator of a midsize to large business

Naturalistic

- Characteristics
  - As a child, you enjoyed collecting insects, leaves, or other natural objects.
  - You enjoy being outdoors.
  - You find that important insights occur during times you spend in nature.
  - You read books and magazines on nature-related topics.
- Learning Strategies
  - During study breaks, take walks outside.
  - Post pictures of outdoor scenes where you study, and play recordings of outdoor sounds while you read.
  - Invite classmates to discuss course work while taking a hike or going on a camping trip.
  - Focus on careers that hold the potential for working outdoors.
- Careers
  - Environmental activist, park ranger, recreation supervisor, historian, museum curator, biologist, criminologist, mechanic, woodworker, construction worker, construction contractor or estimator

Remember this is not an exhaustive list or a formal inventory. Take what you find merely as a starting point to developing your learning strategies. You can invent strategies of your own to cultivate different intelligences.

Developing Your Learning Through Your Senses

Whether you are a visual, auditory, or kinesthetic learner, you can adjust your study methods to fit your individual learning preference. As you review the following suggestions, think about which study methods you already use. You might consider trying one of these suggestions to support your individual learning preference or try a new method to enhance another learning style.

Enhancing Visual Learning

- Preview reading assignments by looking for elements that are highlighted visually—bold headlines, charts, graphs, illustrations, and photographs.
- When taking notes in class, leave plenty of room to later add your own charts, diagrams, tables, and other visuals.
- Whenever an instructor writes information on a blackboard or overhead display, copy it exactly in your notes.
- Transfer your handwritten notes to your computer. Use word-processing software that allows you to format your notes in lists, add headings in different fonts, and create visuals in color.
- Before you begin an exam, quickly sketch a diagram on scratch paper. Use this diagram to summarize the key formulas or facts you want to remember.
- During tests, see whether you can visualize pages from your handwritten notes or images from your computer-based notes.

Enhancing Auditory Learning

- Reinforce memory of your notes and readings by talking about them. When studying, stop often to recite key points and examples in your own words.

- After reciting several summaries of key points and examples, record your favorite version or write it out.
- Read difficult passages in your textbooks slowly and out loud.
- Join study groups, and create short presentations about course topics.
- Visit your instructors during office hours to ask questions.

Enhancing Kinesthetic Learning

- Look for ways to translate course content into 3D models that you can build. While studying biology, for example, create a model of a human cell using different colors of clay.
- Supplement lectures with trips to museums, field observations, lab sessions, tutorials, and other hands-on activities.
- Recite key concepts from your courses while you walk or exercise.
- Intentionally set up situations in which you can learn by trial and error.
- Create a practice test, and write out the answers in the room where you will actually take the exam.

One variation of the VAK system has been called VARK (Fleming 2012). The *R* describes a preference for learning by reading and writing. People with this preference might benefit from translating charts and diagrams into statements, taking notes in lists, and converting those lists into possible items on a multiple-choice test.

Reference

Fleming, Neil. 2012. “VARK: A Guide to Learning Styles.” Accessed November 8, 2012. www.vark-learn.com/.